



Battleships *USS West Virginia* and *USS Tennessee* are engulfed in smoke and flames during the surprise Japanese raid on Pearl Harbor.

**Hess** (1894–1987). On May 10, Hess parachuted into rural Scotland, convinced that he could persuade the British government to ally itself with Germany. Instead, he was arrested and remained a prisoner for the rest of his life.

The chief threat to Britain at this stage in the war lay in the **Battle of the Atlantic**—German attempts to cut off the country's seaborne supplies of food and war material. In May, the German battleship *Bismarck* sortied into the Atlantic. After sinking the Royal Navy battle cruiser *HMS Hood*, *Bismarck* was tracked down, halted by torpedoes dropped from Swordfish biplane aircraft, and then sunk by British battleships. The British and

# 1,000,000

## THE NUMBER OF LENINGRAD'S RESIDENTS THOUGHT TO HAVE DIED DURING THE SIEGE

Canadian navies were less successful at protecting merchant convoys against **German submarines**, however, and losses were soon mounting. The British people felt the effect of this in reduced food rations.

**Britain** did not hesitate to ally itself with the **Soviet Union**, despite Prime Minister Winston

Churchill's (see 1940) strong dislike of Soviet communism. But the British really needed the US to enter the war.

President Roosevelt (see 1933) made no pretense of neutrality. In March, he introduced **Lend-Lease** to supply Britain with military equipment paid for by the US government. American shipyards and factories benefited greatly from this, as did American workers with plentiful and well-paid jobs. Later in the year, free military aid from the US was extended to the Soviet Union.

In August, Roosevelt and Churchill met at Placentia Bay in Newfoundland, Canada, where they signed the **Atlantic Charter**, a statement of joint war aims embodying liberal democratic principles. American warships were already escorting convoys in the eastern Atlantic, and in October a US destroyer was sunk by a German torpedo, but

### Fighting in the snow

A German soldier experiencing the Russian winter during the invasion of the Soviet Union. Axis forces were ill-equipped to cope with the conditions.



“ THAT THE **PEARL HARBOR ATTACK** SHOULD HAVE SUCCEEDED IN ACHIEVING **SURPRISE SEEMS A BLESSING FROM HEAVEN.** ”

Hideki Tojo, Japanese Prime Minister



### Pearl Harbor badge

The slogan “Remember Pearl Harbor” was widely used in the US to inspire patriotic support for the war against the Japanese.

Roosevelt felt he lacked the popular support needed for a declaration of war.

Roosevelt's dilemma was resolved by the Japanese. The US opposed Japan's expansion into Asia, and after Japanese troops entered French Indochina in July **Roosevelt imposed an oil embargo**. Since Japan was entirely dependent on imported oil, its government had the choice of abandoning its military ambitions or fighting a war with the US.

Following a plan advocated by Admiral Isoroku Yamamoto, on



**ISOROKU YAMAMOTO**  
(1884–1943)

In the 1930s, Japanese Admiral Isoroku Yamamoto became a leading advocate of naval air power. As naval commander-in-chief he was the architect of the raid on Pearl Harbor in 1941. He was killed in April 1943 when his aircraft, identified by American intelligence, was shot down over Bougainville Island in the Pacific.

December 7, Japanese carrier aircraft delivered a **surprise attack** on the American naval base at Pearl Harbor in Hawaii. The raid sank or damaged 18 warships and destroyed around 300 aircraft, which severely damaged the US Pacific fleet. Other Japanese forces invaded the Philippines and the British colony of Malaya.

The shock of the raid on Pearl Harbor ensured popular American support for war against Japan, but not against Germany. To the relief of both Churchill and Roosevelt, Hitler chose to declare war on the US in support of his Japanese allies. At the **Arcadia Conference** in Washington at the end of the year, **Britain** and the **US** agreed a **military strategy** that gave priority to defeating the Germans. The two countries also agreed to unify their military command under the Combined Chiefs of Staff.

